

misleading, of course, to posit a “primitive” mentality, as some anthropologists and sociologists do, as if it were something childlike and simple, in contrast to the “sophisticated” mentality of more advanced societies such as that of the Greeks.⁴² In fact, it has been clearly proved (as attested to earlier) how far the myths of primitive societies reflect the complexities of social family structures, and their tales may be profitably compared to classical literature. Yet, there are important differences, and even our earliest literary sources (Homer, Hesiod, and the lyric poets) provide artistic presentations of intellectual, emotional, and spiritual values and concepts in influential works of the highest order, whatever their debts. Greek and Roman mythology shares similar characteristics with the great literatures of the world, which have evolved mythologies of their own, whether or not they have borrowed thematic material from the ancients. Classical mythology has at least as much (if not more) in common with English and American literature (not to mention French and German, among others)⁴³ as it does with preliterate comparisons of oral folktales and the scrutiny of archaic artifacts, however enlightening these studies may be. Greek and Roman mythology and literature look back to an oral and literary past, use it, modify it, and pass on the transformation to the future.

Since the goal of this book is the transmission of the myths themselves as recounted in the Greek and Roman periods, literary myth is inevitably our primary concern. Many of the important myths exist in multiple versions of varying quality, but usually one ancient treatment has been most influential in establishing the prototype or archetype for all subsequent art and thought. Whatever other versions of the Oedipus story exist,⁴⁴ the dramatic treatment by Sophocles has established and imposed the mythical pattern for all time—he is the poet who forces us to see and feel the universal implications. Although his art is self-conscious, literary, and aesthetic, nevertheless the myth *is* the play. We cannot provide complete texts of Greek tragedy, but insofar as possible the original text of the dominant version of a myth will be translated in this book. We believe that a faithful translation or even a paraphrase of the sources is far better than a bald and eclectic retelling in which the essential spirit and artistic subtlety of literary myth is obliterated completely for the sake of scientific analysis. It is commonplace to say that myths are by nature good stories, but some are more childish, confused, and repetitious than others; the really good ones are usually good because they have survived in a form molded by an artist. These are the versions to which we may most profitably apply the criteria established by Aristotle in his *Poetics* on the basis of his experience of Greek tragedy. Is the plot (*mythos*) constructed well with a proper beginning, middle, and end? Have the powerful techniques of recognition and reversal been put to the best use? What about the development of characterization—does the protagonist have a tragic flaw? Most important of all, does the work effect a catharsis (an emotional and spiritual purging) involving the emotions of pity and fear, possibly a goal for all serious mythic art?

There are two indisputable characteristics of the literary myths and legends of Greek and Roman mythology: their artistic merit and the inspiration they have afforded to others. To mention only one example, we have from the ancient world touching renditions of the story of Orpheus and Eurydice. The number of retellings of their tale in Western civilization has been legion (in every possible medium), and it seems that the variations will go on forever.⁴⁵ Thus, we conclude with a short definition that concentrates on the gratifying tenacity of the classical

tradition (in literature and art, but not oral), inextricably woven into the very fabric of our culture:

A classical myth is a story that, through its classical form, has attained a kind of immortality because its inherent archetypal beauty, profundity, and power have inspired rewarding renewal and transformation by successive generations.

The Greeks created a substantial and significant body of myth in various media. The Romans and many subsequent societies have been and continue to be captivated by it. In view of this phenomenal fact, the versions of *Oedipus* by Seneca, Corneille, von Hoffmansthal, and Cocteau have equal validity as personal expressions of the authors' own vision of Sophocles and the myth, for their own time and their own culture. The same may be said of the depiction of a myth on a Greek vase and a painting by Picasso, or a frieze of ancient dancers and a reinterpretation by Isadora Duncan, and the music (no longer to be heard) for a fifth-century performance of *Electra* and the opera by Strauss, and so on. This book has been written out of the desire to provide a lucid and comprehensive introduction to Greek mythology, so that the reader may know, appreciate, and enjoy its miraculous afterlife (*Nachleben*, as the Germans call it), which we feel compelled to survey as well because it is integral to the whole continuum. The creation of classical myth has never really stopped, but from the time of Homer it has constantly been reborn and revitalized, expressed in exciting and challenging new ways through literature, art, music, dance, and film.⁴⁶

Appendix to Chapter 1

Sources for Classical Mythology

Traditional tales were handed down orally until they were stabilized in a written form that spread over a wide area. The geography and topography of the Greek world often made communications by land and sea difficult, and these natural tendencies to cultural separatism were enhanced by tribal, ethnic, and linguistic variations. The Greek myths, therefore, varied greatly from place to place, as did the cults of individual gods. With the coming of writing, perhaps in the eighth century, "standard" versions of myths began to be established, but the sophistication of succeeding generations of poets led also to ingenious variations. Even in the central myths of Athenian drama—whose stories were well known to and expected by their audiences—substantial variations are found, as, for example, in the legends of *Electra*. The problem of variations is especially acute in saga, where differing literary versions and local variations (often based on local pride in the heroic past) make it virtually impossible to identify a "standard" version. This is especially the case with local heroes like Theseus at Athens. Nevertheless, there is a body of recognized principal sources for classical mythology from which major versions may be identified.

To aid the reader, we have included a Timeline of Historical Events and Authors in Chapter 2 (pp. 52–53).

Greek Sources. Pride of place goes to **Homer** (to use the name of the poet to whom the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey* are ascribed), whose poems stabilized the myths of the Olympian gods and exercised an unparalleled influence on all succeeding Greek and Roman writers. The *Iliad* is much more than the story of the wrath

of Achilles or the record of an episode in the tenth year of the Trojan War, for it incorporates many myths of the Olympian and Mycenaean heroes, while its picture of the gods has ever since been the foundation of literary and artistic representations of the Olympian pantheon. The poems themselves, which developed over centuries of oral tradition, perhaps took something like their final form in the eighth century, the *Iliad* being somewhat earlier than the *Odyssey*. The written text was probably stabilized at Athens under the tyranny of Pisistratus during the second half of the sixth century. Our debt to Homeric mythology and legend will be apparent in this book.

Important also for the Olympian gods and the organization of Olympian theology and theogony are the works of **Hesiod**, the Boeotian poet of the late eighth century, perhaps as late as 700. His *Theogony* is our most important source for the relationship of Zeus and the Olympians to their predecessors, the Titans, and other early divinities; it also records how Zeus became supreme and organized the Olympian pantheon. Hesiod's *Works and Days* also contains important mythology. Thus, substantial portions of these works appear in translation or paraphrase in the earlier chapters.

The thirty-three *Homeric Hymns* are a body of poems composed in honor of Olympian deities, most of which embody at least one myth of the god or goddess. Four (those to Demeter, Apollo, Hermes, and Aphrodite) are several hundred lines long and are the most significant sources for those gods' myths; others are very short indeed and appear to be preludes for longer compositions that have not survived. Because of their importance, we have translated all these hymns in their entirety.⁴⁷ The *Homeric Hymns* were composed at widely different times, some perhaps as early as the eighth or seventh century, and some (for example, the *Hymn to Ares*) as late as the fourth century B.C. or Hellenistic times.

Another group of archaic poets whose work is an important source for mythology is the lyric poets, who flourished, especially in the islands of the Aegean Sea, during the seventh and sixth centuries. The lyric tradition was continued in the complex victory *Odes* of the Theban poet **Pindar** during the first half of the fifth century and in the dithyrambs of his rival and contemporary, Bacchylides of Cos. The lyric choruses of the Athenian dramatists also enshrine important versions of myths.

In the fifth century, the flourishing of the Greek city-states led to the creation of great literature and art, nowhere more impressively than at Athens. Here the three great writers of tragedy, **Aeschylus** (who died in 456), **Sophocles**, and **Euripides** (both of whom died in 406), established the authoritative versions of many myths and sagas: a few examples are the *Oresteia* of Aeschylus for the saga of the House of Atreus; the Theban plays of Sophocles for the saga of the family of Oedipus; and the *Bacchae* of Euripides (translated in large part in Chapter 13) for the myths of Dionysus.

After the fifth century, the creative presentation of myths in Greek literature gave way to more contrived versions, many of which were composed by the Alexandrian poets in the third century. Neither the *Hymns* of **Callimachus** nor the hymn to Zeus of Cleanthes has great value as a source for myth, but the epic *Argonautica*, of Apollonius of Rhodes (ca. 260 B.C.), is the single most important source for the saga of the Argonauts. Other Alexandrian versions of the classical myths are discussed in Chapter 27 (available on the companion website).

The principal Greek prose sources are the historians and the mythographers. Of the former, **Herodotus** is preeminent, although some myths are recorded in **Thucydides** (last quarter of the fifth century). Herodotus (born ca. 485) traveled

widely, both within the Greek world and to Persia and Egypt, and he recorded traditional tales wherever he went. Some of his stories contain profound and universal truths of the sort we would associate with myth as well as history; his account of the meeting between Solon and Croesus, which we have translated in Chapter 6, is a perfect example of the developed “historical myth,” giving us insight into Greek interpretations of god and fate that arose out of their factual and mythical storytelling.

The mythographers were late compilers of handbooks of mythology. Of these, the work ascribed to **Apollodorus** with the title *Bibliotheca* (*Library of Greek Mythology*), which is still valuable, perhaps was composed around A.D. 120. The *Periegesis* (*Description of Greece*) of **Pausanias** (ca. A.D. 150) contains many myths in its accounts of religious sites and their works of art.

The philosophers, most notably **Plato** (fourth century B.C.), used myth for didactic purposes, and Plato himself developed out of the tradition of religious tales the “philosophical myth” as a distinct literary form. His myth of Er, for example, is a philosophical allegory about the soul and its existence after death. It is important as evidence for beliefs about the Underworld, and its religious origins go back to earlier centuries, in particular to the speculations of Pythagorean and Orphic doctrine. The Roman poet Vergil (discussed shortly), in his depiction of the afterlife, combines more traditional mythology developed out of Homer with mythical speculations about rebirth and reincarnation found in philosophers like Plato. Thus, by translating all three authors—Homer, Plato, and Vergil—on the realm of Hades (Chapter 15) we have a composite and virtually complete summary of the major mythical and religious beliefs about the afterlife evolved by the Greeks and Romans.

One late philosopher who retold archaic myths for both philosophical and satirical purposes was the Syrian author **Lucian** (born ca. A.D. 120), who wrote in Greek. His satires, often in dialogue form, present the Olympian gods and the old myths with a good deal of humor and critical insight. His version of the judgment of Paris, found in Chapter 19, is a fine example of his art.

Roman Sources. The Greek authors are the foundation of our knowledge of classical myth. Nevertheless, the Roman authors were not merely derivative. **Vergil** (70–19 B.C.) developed the myth of the Trojan hero Aeneas in his epic, the *Aeneid*. In so doing, he preserved the saga of the fall of Troy, a part of the Greek epic cycle that is now lost to us. He also developed the legend of the Phoenician queen Dido and told a number of myths and tales associated with particular Italian localities, such as the story of Hercules at Rome. Several passages from Vergil appear in Chapter 26 as well as Chapter 15.

Vergil’s younger contemporary, **Ovid** (43 B.C.–A.D. 17), is the single most important source for classical mythology after Homer, and his poem *Metamorphoses* (completed ca. A.D. 8) has probably been more influential even than Homer as a source for representations of the classical myths in literature and art. A kind of epic, the poem includes more than 200 legends arranged in a loose chronological framework from the Creation down to Ovid’s own time. Many of the most familiar stories come from Ovid, for example, the stories of Echo and Narcissus, Apollo and Daphne, and Pyramus and Thisbe. Ovid’s poem on the Roman religious calendar, *Fasti*, is a unique source for the myths of the Roman gods, although he completed only the first six months of the religious year. We include a great deal from Ovid, in direct translation or in paraphrase.

The historian **Livy** (59 B.C.–A.D. 17) recorded the foundation myths of Rome in the first book of his *Ab urbe condita*. He is the source for many of the legends from Roman history that are closer to myth than history. Other Roman writers had antiquarian interests, but none wrote continuous accounts comparable with those of Livy.

Later in the first century A.D., a literary renaissance took place during the reign of the emperor Nero (54–68). The tragedies of **Seneca** present important versions of several myths, most notably those of Phaedra and Hippolytus, Medea, and Thyestes, the last named being the only surviving full-length version of the myth.

In the generation following Seneca, there was a revival of epic. The *Argonautica* of **Valerius Flaccus** (ca. 80) and the *Thebaid* of **Statius** (d. 96) are important versions of their respective sagas. After this time, there are few original works worth notice. One exception is a novel by the African rhetorician **Apuleius** (b. 123) formally titled *Metamorphoses* but better known to us as *The Golden Ass*. This is our source for the tale of Cupid and Psyche, while its final book is invaluable for its account of the mysteries of Isis.

Interest in mythology continued to be shown in a number of handbooks of uncertain date. We have mentioned the *Bibliotheca* of Apollodorus in Greek; in Latin, compendia were written by **Hyginus** (perhaps in the mid-second century) and Fulgentius (perhaps an African bishop of the sixth century). This tradition was revived during the Renaissance, especially in Italy, and we discuss some of the important handbooks of mythology in Chapter 27 (available on the companion website).

The Eclectic Variety of the Sources. It is readily apparent that this literary heritage offers infinite variety. The religious tales of Hesiod contrast with the sophisticated stories of Ovid. The historical legend of Herodotus differs in character from the legendary history of Homer. The philosophical myth of Plato and the romantic storytelling of Apuleius reveal contrasting spiritual hues. The dramatic environments of Aeschylus and Seneca are worlds apart. Yet *all* these authors from different periods and with diverse art provide the rich, eclectic heritage from which a survey of Greco-Roman mythology must be drawn.

Translations. All the Greek and Roman works named here (except for the late Latin handbooks of mythology) are available in inexpensive translations. The Loeb series includes texts with facing translations, the latter of widely varying quality and readability, with improved, new editions made available annually. The translations published by Penguin and by the University of Chicago Press are generally both reliable and in some cases distinguished. But there is considerable choice, and contemporary translations (some of them excellent) of standard works appear with surprising and gratifying frequency. Yet one needs to be wary. Dover Publications offers several Greek and Roman translations that should not be purchased indiscriminately; dramas are available individually, in thrift editions at an extremely modest price, but the poetic translations by Sir George Young (1837–1930), for example, may be a bit more difficult for modern readers than they bargained for; at the same time, the series includes the acceptable *Medea* by Rex Warner. The free translations of the *Oresteia* and of Ovid's *Metamorphoses* by the distinguished poet Ted Hughes stand as exceptional reinterpretations but can hardly serve as the basis for determining what Sophocles actually said—a vital concern for the student of mythology. Among the translations available for Homer, Stanley Lombardo's *Iliad* and *Odyssey* deserve special commendation.

They bring the poems to life for an audience of today. Richmond Lattimore offers a most faithful and poetic transmission of Homer's *Iliad*. Caveat emptor! Oxford University Press in its series Oxford World's Classics offers attractive paperback volumes of good translations of many works that might supplement our text.

The translations presented in this book are our own, and we attempt to offer accurate and accessible versions for the reader who knows no Greek or Latin and wants to come as close as possible to the original sources.

Select Bibliography

Interpretation, Analysis, and Comparative Studies

- Ackerman, Robert.** *The Myth and Ritual School: J. G. Frazer and the Cambridge Ritualists*. New York: Routledge, 2002. An examination of works by Frazer, Jane Harrison, Gilbert Murray, F. M. Cornford, and A. B. Cook. The last chapter explores the application of myth and ritual to postclassical literature.
- Anderson, Graham.** *Fairytale in the Ancient World*. New York: Routledge, 2000.
- Burkert, Walter.** *Structure and History in Greek Mythology and Ritual*. Berkeley: University of California Press, 1979. By far the best explanation of the significance of structural theories.
- Csapo, Eric.** *Theories of Mythology*. New York: Blackwell, 2004. A history of theories of myth, with sample readings on how to interpret myths.
- Dowden, K.** *The Uses of Greek Mythology*. New York: Routledge, 1992. A judicious assessment of psychoanalytical approaches on pp. 32–34 and 180.
- Dundes, A., ed.** *Sacred Narrative: Readings in the Theory of Myth*. Berkeley: University of California Press, 1984. A collection of writing by major interpreters of myth, including Frazer, Eliade, Malinowski, Jung, and Lévi-Strauss.
- Edmunds, Lowell, ed.** *Approaches to Greek Myth*. Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1989.
- Eliade, Mircea.** *Cosmos and History: The Myth of the Eternal Return*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1954. Perhaps the best among his many works to serve as an introduction.
- Ellis, John M.** *One Fairy Story Too Many*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1983. A study of the text and history of the work of the brothers Grimm, which, Ellis claims, is a fraud. A warning to those who have too blind a faith in oral myth that has been made literary.
- Felton, D.** *Haunted Greece and Rome: Ghost Stories from Classical Antiquity*. Austin: University of Texas Press, 1999. A folkloric and literary analysis of ancient ghost stories and the influence and development of themes in modern times.
- Frazer, James G.** *The New Golden Bough: A New Abridgement of the Classic Work*. Edited by Theodor H. Gaster. New York: Criterion Books, 1959; New York: Mentor Books, 1964.
- Graf, Fritz.** *Greek Mythology: An Introduction*. Translated by Thomas Marier. Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1993 [1987]. A history of the interpretation of the principal Greek myths from the seventeenth century to the present.
- Holzberg, Niklas.** *The Ancient Fable: An Introduction*. Translated by Christine Jackson-Holzberg. Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2002.
- . *Ancient Folklore: An Introduction*. Translated by Christine Jackson-Holzberg. Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2002. A critical study of the fable in the texts of Greek and Roman authors.
- Kirk, G. S.** *Myth: Its Meaning and Function in Ancient and Other Cultures*. Berkeley: University of California Press, 1970. Valuable for its critical views of comparative studies.
- . *The Nature of Greek Myths*. Baltimore, MD: Penguin Books, 1974. Useful for its treatment of different approaches to myth.

- Leach, E.** *Claude Lévi-Strauss*. New York: Viking Press, 1970. A good exposition of Lévi-Strauss; in the chapter "The Structure of Myth," Leach offers structural analysis of several Greek myths.
- Leeming, David Adams.** *Mythology: The Voyage of the Hero*. 3d ed. New York: Oxford University Press, 1998. A comparative study of major themes in various mythologies, including those of Greece and Rome.
- Lefkowitz, Mary.** *Greek Gods, Human Lives: What We Can Learn from Myths*. New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2005.
- Lévi-Strauss, Claude.** *The Savage Mind*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1966 [1962].
- . *The Raw and the Cooked*. Translated by J. and D. Weightman. New York: Harper & Row, 1969. Volume 1 of the four volumes of *Mythologiques*; its "Overture" is the best introduction to Lévi-Strauss.
- Malinowski, B.** *Magic, Science, and Religion*. New York: Doubleday, 1955. Includes "Myth in Primitive Psychology," 1989 [1926].
- Propp, Vladimir.** *Morphology of the Folktale*. 2d ed. Translated by Lawrence Scott. Austin: University of Texas Press, 1968 [1928]. The pioneer work in the structural theory of myth.
- Sebeok, Thomas A., ed.** *Myth: A Symposium*. Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1965.
- Segal, Robert A.** *Joseph Campbell: An Introduction*. New York: Meridian, 1997 [1987].
- , ed. *Literary Criticism and Myth*. New York: Garland, 1996. A collection in six volumes of important writings by major writers.
- Strenski, Ivan.** *Four Theories of Myth in Twentieth-Century History: Cassirer, Eliade, Lévi-Strauss and Malinowski*. Iowa City: University of Iowa Press, 1987. An iconoclastic judgment of mythography and mythographers. For Strenski (p. 194), no such thing as *myth* exists: "Rather, what exists is the artifact 'myth' along with the 'industry' manufacturing the concept as it is used here and there."
- , ed. *Malinowski and the Work of Myth*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1992. Collection of central writings by Malinowski.
- Struck, Peter T.** *Birth of a Symbol: Ancient Readers at the Limit of Their Texts*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2004. An exploration of how the ancient Greek literary critics and theorists invented and developed ideas of symbolism and allegorical interpretation.
- Thompson, Stith.** *The Folktale*. Berkeley: University of California Press, 1977 [1946].
- . *Motif-Index of Folk-Literature*. 6 vols. Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1966. The basic reference book for folktale motifs.
- Vernant, J.-P.** *Myth and Society in Ancient Greece*. Translated by J. Lloyd. New York: Zone Books, 1990 [1974].
- Von Hendy, Andrew.** *The Modern Construction of Myth*. Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2002. A critical account of theorizing about myth from the eighteenth century on.

Myth and Psychology

- Bolen, Jean Shinoda.** *Goddesses in Everywoman: A New Psychology of Women*. New York: Harper & Row, 1984. A Jungian psychologist provides archetypal descriptions of the Greek and Roman goddesses and shows how they provide meaningful patterns for understanding the character, behavior, and personality of women today. Two sequels followed: *Gods in Everyman* (1989) and *Goddesses in Older Women* (2002).
- Eisner, Robert.** *The Road to Daulis: Psychoanalysis, Psychology, and Classical Mythology*. Syracuse, NY: Syracuse University Press, 1987. Chapters include "Oedipus and His Kind," "Electra and Other Monsters," and "Apollo and His Boys."
- Evans, Richard I.** *Dialogue with C. G. Jung*. 2d ed. New York: Praeger, 1981. Basic concepts clearly presented through Jung's own words.

- Jung, C. G.**, *Psyche and Symbol: A Selection from the Writings of C. G. Jung*. Translated by V. S. de Laszlo. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1991.
- Lloyd-Jones, H.** "Psychoanalysis and the Study of the Ancient World," in P. Horden, ed., *Freud and the Humanities*. New York: St. Martin's Press, 1985, pp. 152–180. (Reprinted in *Greek Comedy [etc.]: The Academic Papers of Sir Hugh Lloyd-Jones*. New York: Oxford University Press, 1990, pp. 281–305.) Hostile criticism of psychoanalytical theory by an authoritative classical scholar.
- Mullahy, Patrick.** *Oedipus Myth and Complex: A Review of Psychoanalytic Theory*. New York: Grove Press, 1955. An excellent survey.
- Pedrick, Victoria.** *Euripides, Freud, and the Romance of Belonging*. Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 2007. Deals with ancient and modern concerns with origins, identity, parental embrace, and abandonment.
- Schneiderman, Leo.** *The Psychology of Myth, Folklore, and Religion*. Chicago: Nelson-Hall, 1981. Chapters include "The Mystical Quest," "The Cult of Fertility," and "Jason and the Totem."
- Walker, Steven.** *Jung and the Jungians on Myth*. New York: Routledge, 2002.
- Woolger, Jennifer Barker, and Woolger, Roger J.** *The Goddess Within: A Guide to the Eternal Myths That Shape Women's Lives*. New York: Fawcett Columbine, 1987. The major goddesses considered as types, with a bibliography of novels and plays and a list of movies (on video), identifying characters that embody these types.

Gender, Homosexuality, and the Interpretation of Mythology

- Two scholarly journals, *Arethusa* and *Helios*, are especially receptive to feminist scholarship. *Arethusa* 6 (1973) and 11 (1978) have been mostly reprinted in J. J. Peradotto and J. P. Sullivan, eds., *Women in the Ancient World: The Arethusa Papers* (Albany: State University of New York, 1984). *Helios* 12, 2 (1985) contains a debate on "Classical Studies vs. Women's Studies," by Marilyn Skinner, Mary Lefkowitz, and Judith Hallett.
- Bacchilega, Cristina.** *Gender and Narrative Strategies*. University Park: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1997. The representation of women in four classic fairytales and postmodern revisions in literature and film.
- Cantarella, Eva.** *Bisexuality in the Ancient World*. Translated by Cormac Ó Cuilleánáin. 2d ed. New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2002.
- Davidson, James.** *The Greeks and Greek Love: A Bold New Exploration of the Ancient World*. New York: Random House, 2009.
- Doherty, Lillian E.** *Gender and the Interpretation of Classical Myth*. London: Duckworth, 2001.
- Dover, K. J.** *Greek Homosexuality*. Updated with a new postscript. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1989 [1980].
- Dynes, Wayne R., and Stephen Donaldson, eds.** *Homosexuality in the Ancient World: (Studies in Homosexuality, vol. 1)*. New York: Taylor & Francis (Garland), 1992. A collection of papers in their original languages about various aspects of Greek and Roman homosexuality.
- Fantham, Elaine, Helene Peet Foley, Natalie Boymel Kampen, Sarah B. Pomeroy, and H. A. Shapiro.** *Women in the Classical World: Image and Text*. New York: Oxford University Press, 1994.
- Fone, Byrne.** *Homophobia: A History*. New York: Metropolitan Books (Henry Holt), 2000. An important study, the first part of which deals with the ancient world.
- Gomme, A. W.** "The Position of Women at Athens in the Fifth and Fourth Centuries B.C." *Essays in Greek History and Literature*. New York: Essay Index Reprint Series, Books for Libraries Press, 1967.

- Halperin, David M.** *One Hundred Years of Homosexuality, and Other Essays on Greek Love*. New York: Routledge, 1989. Argues that modern attitudes toward homosexuality are inadequate for an understanding of sexual mores in the ancient world.
- Hawley, Richard, and Barbara Levick, eds.** *Women in Antiquity: New Assessments*. New York: Routledge, 1995. Includes discussion of women's roles in religious ritual and mythology.
- Hubbard, Thomas K., ed.** *Homosexuality in Greece and Rome: A Sourcebook of Basic Documents*. Berkeley: University of California Press, 2003. A wide-ranging, invaluable collection from archaic Greek lyric to later Greco-Roman antiquity.
- Lear, Andrew, and Eva Cantarella.** *Images of Ancient Greek Pederasty*. New York: Routledge, 2008.
- Lefkowitz, Mary R.** *Women in Greek Myth*. 2d ed. Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 2007.
- Pomeroy, Sarah B.** *Goddesses, Whores, Wives, and Slaves*. New York: Schocken, 1975. See especially Chapters 2 and 6.
- Sissa, Giulia.** *Sex and Sensuality in the Ancient World*. Translated by George Staunton. New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2008. A demonstration of how modern concepts of sexuality have emerged from ancient cultures, including portrayals of Medea, Clytemnestra, and Jocasta, with an argument for the centrality of heterosexual desire and against the overemphasis of homosexuality.
- Skinner, Marilyn B.** *Sexuality in Greek and Roman Culture*. New York: Wiley-Blackwell, 2005. A comprehensive survey based on literary, artistic, and archaeological evidence and covering a variety of subjects, with emphasis on ancient attitudes toward sexual identity and gender as compared with those of contemporary culture.
- Thornton, Bruce S.** *Eros: The Myth of Ancient Greek Sexuality*. Boulder, CO: Westview Press, 1997. An insightful exploration of the destructiveness of Eros in Greek imagery and metaphor and the links between ancient and present-day attitudes and concerns about sex, love, and family.
- Williams, Craig A.** *Roman Homosexuality: Ideologies of Masculinity in Classical Antiquity*. New York: Oxford University Press, 1999.
- Winkler, John J.** *Constraints of Desire: The Anthropology of Sex and Gender in Ancient Greece*. New York: Routledge, 1990. A study of the sexuality of women (e.g., Penelope and Sappho) and the interpretation of rituals (e.g., in honor of Demeter, Aphrodite, and Adonis).

Iconography, Religion, and Feminist Interpretations

- Ehrenberg, Margaret.** *Women in Prehistory*. Norman: University of Oklahoma Press, 1989. The role of women from the Paleolithic to the Iron Age, with a consideration of matriarchy in Minoan Crete.
- Eller, Cynthia.** *The Myth of Matriarchal Prehistory: Why an Invented Past Won't Give Women a Future*. New York: Beacon Press, 2000. An argument against the validity of interpretations of feminists such as Marija Gimbutas, who imagine in a time of goddess worship a gynocentric golden age before the onset of patriarchy.
- Gimbutas, Marija.** *The Language of the Goddesses*. Foreword by Joseph Campbell. New York: Harper & Row, 1989. An analysis of the symbols in the archaeological evidence under the major categories of "Life-Giving," "The Renewing and Eternal Earth," "Death and Regeneration," and "Energy and Unfolding."
- Marinatos, Nanno.** *The Goddess and the Warrior: The Naked Goddess and Mistress of the Animals in Early Greek Religion*. New York: Routledge, 2000. Traces the origins of concepts of the female goddess in the Bronze Age, with emphasis on

Circe, Medusa, and Artemis, who is deemed to have supervised the initiation of males.

Zeitlin, Froma. *Playing the Other: Gender and Society in Classical Greek Literature*.

Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1996. Many of the essays are revisions of previously published material.

Art

Carpenter, T. H. *Art and Myth in Ancient Greece*. New York: Thames & Hudson, 1990.

Condos, Theony. *Star Myths of the Greeks and Romans; A Sourcebook*. Grand Rapids, MI: Phanes, 1997. Includes the only surviving works on the constellation myths from antiquity: an epitome of *The Constellations* of Eratosthenes, never before translated into English, and the *The Poetic Astronomy* of Hyginus; also commentaries on each constellation myth.

Freedman, Luba. *The Revival of the Olympian Gods in Renaissance Art*. New York: Cambridge University Press, 2003.

Gantz, Timothy. *Early Greek Myth: A Guide to Literary and Artistic Sources*. 2 vols. Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1996. An excellent resource.

Kalil, L., ed. *Lexicon Iconographicum Mythologicae Classicae*. 8 double vols. Zurich: Artemis, 1981–1997. The most complete source for ancient representations of classical myths, with extensive essays (in English, French, German, and Italian), photographs, and bibliography for each entry.

Reid, Jane Davidson. *The Oxford Guide to Classical Mythology in the Arts 1300–1900s*. 2 vols. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1993. The most comprehensive reference work listing works of art, music, and literature, with bibliography.

Snodgrass, Anthony. *Homer and the Artists: Text and Picture in Early Greek Art*.

New York: Cambridge University Press, 1998. Argues that early Greek artists considered Homeric versions not as primary sources but as only one of possible variants.

Torrijos, Rosa López. *Mythology and History in the Great Paintings of the Prado*.

London: Scala Books, 1998. The majority of the paintings reproduced and discussed deal with Greek and Roman mythology.

Van Keuren, Frances. *Guide to Research in Classical Art and Mythology*. Chicago:

American Library Association, 1991. A bibliographical reference book, clearly arranged by topic and period.

The Gods, Religion, and the Occult

See the Select Bibliography at the end of Chapter 6.

Additional Material

Books

Biography: Beard, Mary. *The Invention of Jane Harrison*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2002. A portrayal of anthropologist Jane Ellen Harrison (1850–1928) and her career in the milieu of Classical scholarship at Cambridge of the period, along with her younger protégé Eugenie Sellers, virtually forgotten today.

Biography: Robinson, Annabel. *The Life and Work of Jane Ellen Harrison*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2002.

Novel: Calasso, Roberto. *The Marriage of Cadmus and Harmony*. New York: Knopf, 1993. An idiosyncratic retelling of many ancient myths, but capacious enough to include musings on the interaction of myth and the contemporary world.

- Poetry*: The following books concern poems in English on mythological subjects.
- Bush, Douglas. *Mythology and the Renaissance: Tradition in English Poetry*. New York: Norton, 1963 [1932]. Includes a chronological list of poems on mythological subjects.
- De Nicola, Deborah, ed. *Orpheus and Company: Contemporary Poems on Greek Mythology*. Lebanon, NH: University Press of New England, 1999.
- Harrison, S. J., ed. *Living Classics: Greece and Rome in Contemporary Poetry in English*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2009. This collection of essays explores the extensive use of Latin and Greek literary texts in a range of recent poetry written in English by scholars and poets, including Tony Harrison, Seamus Heaney, and Michael Longley.
- Kossmann, Nina, ed. *Gods and Mortals: Modern Poems on Classical Myths*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2001 [1971]. An impressive collection by internationally renowned poets.
- Mayerson, Philip. *Classical Mythology in Literature, Art, and Music*. Newburyport, MA: Focus Publishing, 2001. This well-written survey embraces far more than poetry inspired by classical mythology, as its title informs us.

DVDs

- Documentary*: Joseph Campbell. *A Biographical Portrait: The Hero's Journey*. Wellspring. A good introduction to Campbell and mythic themes. See also *Sukhavati (Place of Bliss)*; *A Mythic Journey* (the title refers to Campbell's life calling); *Mythos 1: The Shaping of Our Mythic Tradition*; *Mythos 2: The Shaping of the Eastern Tradition*; and *The Power of Myth* (the PBS series with Bill Moyers). All four Acorn Media.

Notes

1. G. S. Kirk, *The Nature of Greek Myths* (Harmondsworth, UK: Penguin Books, 1974), p. 27. Kirk identifies a "traditional tale" as a myth that has "succeeded in becoming traditional . . . [and is] important enough to be passed from generation to generation."
2. See *The Routledge Handbook of Greek Mythology* (New York: Routledge, 2003). This seventh edition is a completely revised version of H. J. Rose's *Handbook of Greek Mythology*.
3. *Legend*, like *myth*, may be used as a general term in its broadest sense. Often, however, it is defined as equivalent to *saga* and refers to stories inspired by actual persons and events. Thus, for us *legend* and *saga* are one and the same. Many prefer the German word *Märchen* for the designation of folktales because of the pioneering work of the brothers Grimm (1857) in collecting and collating variations of oral tales and publishing their own versions.
4. Graham Anderson, *Fairytales in the Ancient World* (London: Routledge, 2000), p. 1. Anderson has identified several motifs from familiar fairytales in Greek and Roman stories (those of Cinderella, Snow White, Red Riding Hood, and Bluebeard, among many others) and offers a comparison of Cupid and Psyche and Beauty and the Beast.
5. Sometimes *fable* is also applied as a general term, but it is better to restrict its meaning to designate a story in which the characters are animals endowed with human traits, the primary purpose being moral and didactic.
6. Cf. Paul Veyne, *Did the Greeks Believe in Their Myths? An Essay on the Constitutive Imagination* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1988 [1983]), on the creation of truth and history.
7. This has become a commonplace explanation of the human need for mythology; it has been formulated with particular conviction by Leszek Kolakowski in his *The Presence of Myth* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1989 [1972]). Kolakowski frames his discussion in terms of a contrast between myth and science; for him science in its technological aspect represents the truth that is to be distinguished from myth.

8. Martha Graham, *Blood Memory* (New York: Doubleday, 1991), p. 4.
9. Ivan Strenski, *Four Theories of Myth in Twentieth-Century History* (Iowa City: Iowa University Press, 1987), pp. 71–128, provides a clear critique of Eliade's complexity. Among Eliade's many works, we single out in this context *Myths, Dreams, and Mysteries* (London: Harvill, 1960) and *Myth and Reality* (New York: Harper & Row, 1963).
10. See Friedrich Max Müller, *Comparative Mythology: An Essay* (1856; reprint of rev. ed. of 1909, Salem, NH: Ayer, 1977), which includes an "Introductory Preface on Solar Mythology" by Abram Smythe Palmer and a parody by R. F. Littledale, "The Oxford Solar Myth," that is, Müller himself. For an assessment of Müller's theories, see the essay by R. M. Dorson, "The Eclipse of Solar Mythology," in T. A. Sebeok, ed., *Myth: A Symposium* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press), pp. 25–63.
11. Also, "contextualism" or "situationism" and "behaviorism" are to be found in Aristotle's writings, "the first scientific work on bio-social psychology . . . practically unknown to students of human nature today." For these and other observations explaining the profound debt of modern psychology to the perceptions of Greek dramatists and philosophers, see Patrick Mullahy, *Oedipus Myth and Complex: A Review of Psychoanalytic Theory* (New York: Grove Press, 1955), pp. 335–337.
12. "The Interpretation of Dreams," in A. A. Brill, ed., *The Basic Writings of Sigmund Freud* (New York: Random House, Modern Library, 1938), p. 308, quoted at greater length by Mullahy as an introduction to Chapter 1 of *Oedipus Myth*. Plato in his *Republic* (571C) has a famous description of the unbridled nature of dreams that includes the mention of intercourse with one's mother.
13. We do not attempt to summarize a complex and fruitful subject; see Mullahy, *Oedipus Myth*, pp. 102–113. For the beginner, Richard Wollheim, *Freud* (Glasgow: William Collins, 1971), provides a concise introduction to Freudian thought; similarly, one might consult Frieda Fordham, *An Introduction to Jung's Psychology*, 3d ed. (Baltimore, MD: Penguin Books, 1966), with a foreword by Jung. The bibliography for both Freud and Jung is, not surprisingly, voluminous and accessible.
14. Richard I. Evans, *Dialogue with C. G. Jung*, 2d ed. (New York: Praeger, 1981), p. 167.
15. Cf. Joseph Campbell, *Myths to Live By* (New York: Viking Press, 1972). Typically and unfortunately, Campbell does not pay enough attention to the Greeks and the Romans.
16. Jan Bremmer, "Oedipus and the Greek Oedipus Complex," in J. Bremmer, ed., *Interpretations of Greek Mythology* (London: Routledge, 1988), pp. 41–59 (the quotation is from note 42).
17. E. O. Wilson, *Consilience* (New York: Knopf, 1988), pp. 81–85 and 193–196.
18. See Jonathan Engel, *The Rise of Psychotherapy in the United States* (New York: Gotham Books, 2008). The quotation is from the review by Scott Stossel in the *New York Times Book Review* (December 21, 2008).
19. See R. L. Gordon, ed., *Myth, Religion, and Society: Structuralist Essays by M. Detienne, L. Gernet, J.-P. Vernant, and P. Vidal-Naquet* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1981).
20. Robert Graves, *The Greek Myths* (Baltimore, MD: Penguin Books, 1993 [1955]), vol. 1, p. 10. The basic assumption that permeates his writing has merit: an early matriarchal society once existed in Europe with the worship of a great mother deity, and subsequently there was an invasion of a patriarchal society from the north and east; but many of his detailed arguments are extravagant and rash. This work presents a brilliant mine of information that obscures mythical fact with fictional hypotheses.
21. E. R. Leach, *Political Systems of Highland Burma* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1954), p. 13; quoted in Kirk, *Nature of Greek Myths*, pp. 67 and 226. The best short expositions of the ritualist theory are the essays by Lord Raglan, "Myth and Ritual," and S. E. Hyman, "The Ritual View of Myth and the Mythic," in Sebeok, *Myth*, pp. 122–135 and 136–153.

22. Bronislaw Malinowski, "Myth in Primitive Psychology" (1926); reprinted in *Magic, Science and Religion* (New York: Doubleday, 1955).
23. Bronislaw Malinowski, *Argonauts of the Western Pacific* (New York: Dutton, 1961 [1922]), p. 25. For a survey of Malinowski's views in a historical context, see Strenski, *Four Theories of Myth*, pp. 42–69.
24. The best introduction to Lévi-Strauss is the "Overture" to *The Raw and the Cooked*, and classicists should read his article "The Structural Study of Myth" (which includes his interpretation of the Oedipus myth), to be found in Sebeok, *Myth*, pp. 81–106.
25. Lévi-Strauss, quoted in G. S. Kirk, *Myth: Its Meaning and Function in Ancient and Other Cultures* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1971), p. 44.
26. Vladimir Propp, *Morphology of the Folktale*, 2d ed., rev. (Austin: University of Texas Press, 1968 [1928]). Chapter 2 (pp. 19–24) is the essential statement of Propp's methodology.
27. Propp's thirty-one functions are set out in his third chapter, pp. 25–65. The term *motifeme* was coined by the anthropologist Alan Dundes.
28. This sequence of five functions is worked out by Walter Burkert, *Structure and History in Greek Mythology and Ritual* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1979), n. 22, pp. 6–7. He points out that the metamorphosis of the mother (e.g., Callisto into a bear, Io into a cow) is not part of a fixed sequence of functions.
29. See W. Burkert, *Creation of the Sacred: Tracks of Biology in Early Religion* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1996), especially Chapter 3, "The Core of a Tale."
30. See Strenski, *Four Theories of Myth*, pp. 42–69, for a critical discussion of Malinowski's definition of myth.
31. Some attempt to find the oral antecedent of a literary version of a Greek myth and turn to late compendia of tales such as that of Apollodorus to identify the original version. The original version of a myth (oral or literary and usually hypothetical) is sometimes designated as the Ur-myth. It is difficult and often impossible to ascertain with any certainty the precise details or the date of versions of a classical story told by a deceased author, but the pursuit is interesting and can be rewarding—but it is beyond the scope of this introductory book.
32. Robert A. Segal, *In Quest of the Hero* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1990), pp. xi–xxii, identifies differences among Freud, Jung, and Campbell in their psychological explanations of the hero myth.
33. Robert A. Segal, *Joseph Campbell: An Introduction* (New York: Meridian, 1997 [1987]). The bibliography for Joseph Campbell is considerable. See, for example, *The Hero with a Thousand Faces*, 2d ed., Bollingen Series 17 (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1968); *The Masks of God*, 4 vols. (New York: Viking Press, 1959–1968). These are preferable to his works for a more general audience of television viewers, for whom his approach is exceedingly attractive, but disappointing to the serious classicist who expects a deeper appreciation of Greek and Roman mythology; see *The Power of Myth*, with Bill Moyers (New York: Doubleday, 1988).
34. Numbers 1 and 16 in D. A. Campbell's *Greek Lyric* (New York: St. Martin's Press, 1967), vol. 1.
35. Helene P. Foley, ed., *The Homeric Hymn to Demeter: Translation, Commentary, and Interpretive Essays*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1998.
36. Marilyn Katz, *Penelope's Renown: Meaning and Indeterminacy in the Odyssey* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1991), p. 13. A starting point for the study of feminism and mythology is Mary R. Lefkowitz, *Women in Greek Myth* (Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1986). The "moderate" approach of the author, however, is vigorously criticized by some feminists.
37. See Joan Breton Connelly, *Portrait of a Priestess: Women and Ritual in Ancient Greece* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2007).
38. A. W. Gomme, "The Position of Women at Athens in the Fifth and Fourth Centuries B.C." in A. W. Gomme, ed., *Essays in Greek History and Literature*. (Freeport, NY: Essay Index Reprint Series, Books for Libraries Press, 1967 [1925]).

39. Eli Sagan, *The Honey and the Hemlock, Democracy and Paranoia in Ancient Athens and Modern America* (New York: HarperCollins, 1991). This work by a sociologist is all too typical of many revisionist studies (including some by classicists who should know better) in its blurring of definitions of citizenship and the differing rights and roles of men and women, of different classes, and as citizens, resident aliens, or slaves.
40. A statement that needs no modification, despite the book by Lloyd Llewellyn-Jones, *Aphrodite's Tortoise: The Veiled Women of Ancient Greece* (Swansea: Classical Press of Wales, 2003). There are no sound reasons to concur with his conclusion (p. 1) "that the veiling of the female head or face was part of a male ideology that required women to be silent invisible creatures, like mute tortoises contained and hidden within their shells," since it is based on preconceived misconceptions about Greek society, its customs, and its mores over a long period of time (from 900 B.C. to A.D. 200), concerning which there is abundant testimony to the contrary. His arguments from silence are no real evidence at all.
41. G. W. Bowerstock, "Men and Boys," *The New York Review of Books*, September 24, 2009, pp. 12–14.
42. This was the attitude, for example, of L. Lévy-Bruhl, *Primitive Mentality* (New York: Macmillan, 1923 [1922]).
43. A realization forcefully brought home after a reading of George Steiner, *Antigones* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1984), which discusses treatments of the Antigone theme in European literature; also Ian Donaldson, *The Rapes of Lucretia: A Myth and Its Transformations* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1982). Jane Davidson Reid provides a comprehensive collection of works indebted to Greece and Rome in *The Oxford Guide to Classical Mythology in the Arts, 1300–1990s*, 2 vols. (New York: Oxford University Press, 1991).
44. See Lowell Edmunds, *Oedipus: The Ancient Legend and Its Later Analogues* (Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1985), a survey of the many variations in ancient, medieval, and modern versions of this eternal myth.
45. See the bibliography on Orpheus at the end of Chapter 16; and we should not forget the Orpheus of music, theater, and the dance. A most fascinating collection of poetry by internationally acclaimed authors, *Gods and Mortals: Modern Poems on Classical Myths*, edited by Nina Kossman (New York: Oxford University Press, 2001), includes thirty-one works inspired by the theme of Orpheus and Eurydice. See also Deborah DeNicols, ed., *Orpheus and Company: Contemporary Poems on Greek Mythology* (Lebanon, NH: University Press of New England, 1999).
46. *The Classical Tradition*, ed. Anthony Grafton, Glenn W. Most, and Salvatore Settis (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2010). Many essays on a wide variety of subjects, arranged alphabetically, for scholars, students, and general readers illustrate how the classical tradition has deeply influenced and shaped civilization.
47. Invaluable is the Greek edition by T. W. Allen, W. R. Halliday, and E. E. Sikes (New York: Oxford University Press, 1963 [1934]). See also J. S. Clay, *The Politics of Olympus: Form and Meaning in the Major Homeric Hymns* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1989).

Historical Background of Greek Mythology

At last I was able to realize the dream of my whole life, and to visit at my leisure the scene of those events which had such an intense interest for me, and the country of the heroes whose adventures had delighted and comforted my childhood.

—HEINRICH SCHLIEMANN

AS WE HAVE ALREADY seen, the historical dimension is a prominent feature of Greek legend or saga, and an outline of the historical background will be helpful for a fuller understanding.¹ Our knowledge of the early history of Greece and the Aegean is constantly changing, thanks to the fresh discoveries of archaeologists and other scholars. Consequently, our view of Greek religion and mythology has been (and will continue to be) modified by new knowledge, not least in the area of legends that cluster around the sagas of Mycenae and Troy.

The foundations of modern archaeological work in the Mycenaean world were laid by the brilliant pioneer Heinrich **Schliemann** (1822–1890), who, because of his love of Greek antiquity in general and Homer in particular, was inspired by a faith in the ultimate historical authenticity of Greek legend. Although Schliemann's character and achievement have come under vehement attack, it is impossible to deny him pride of place.² In the 1870s, he went to Troy, Mycenae, and Tiryns and confirmed the reality of the wealth, grandeur, and power of the cities, kings, and heroes of Minoan-Mycenaean saga. Sir Arthur **Evans** followed at the turn of the century, unearthing the splendid and grand complex of the palace of Minos at Cnossus in Crete. A whole new world had been opened up.

For a long time, it was believed that Greece had not been inhabited before the Neolithic period. But we know today that the country was settled in Paleolithic times (before 70,000 B.C.). With the present state of excavation and study, our knowledge of this early period remains tentative. Evidence for the Neolithic period (ca. 6000–3000 B.C.) is more abundant. Archaeology has revealed settled agricultural communities (i.e., outlines of houses, pottery, tools, and graves). It is conjectured that the Neolithic inhabitants came from the east and the north. For our purposes, it is noteworthy that evidence of religion seems



apparent; particularly significant are little female idols, their sexuality exaggerated by the depiction of swollen bellies, buttocks, and full breasts. Male figures (some ithyphallic) also are found, although in far fewer numbers. Was a fertility mother-goddess worshiped in this early period and perhaps already associated with a male consort? The interpretation of prehistoric icons for an understanding of the worship of gods and goddesses in patriarchal and matriarchal societies has become a subject of intense scrutiny.³

The Bronze Age

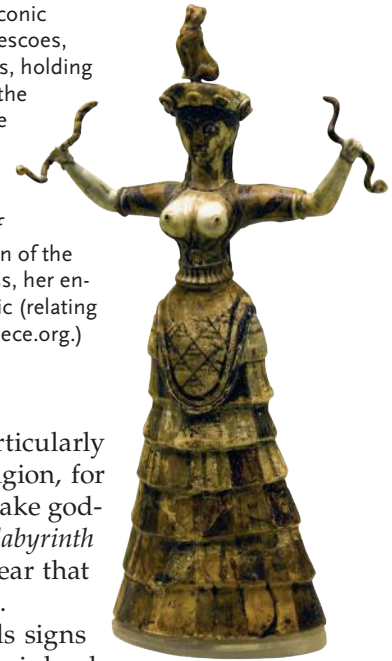
The Stone Age gave way to the Bronze Age in Greece, Crete, and the Islands with a migration from the east (the movement was from Asia Minor across the Aegean to the southern Peloponnesus and up into Greece). These invaders were responsible for building the great Minoan civilization of Crete. The Bronze Age is divided into three major periods: Early, Middle, and Late; these periods are also labeled according to geographical areas. Thus, the Bronze Age in Crete is designated as Minoan (from the tradition of King Minos); for the Islands the term is Cycladic (the Cyclades are the islands that encircle Delos); in Greece it is called Helladic (Hellas is the Greek name for the country). The Late Bronze Age on the mainland (i.e., the late Helladic period) is also identified as the Mycenaean Age, from the citadel of power (Mycenae) dominant in Greece during this period. The chronology with the terminology is as follows:⁴

3000–2000 B.C.	Early Bronze Age	Early Minoan Early Cycladic Early Helladic
2000–1600 B.C.	Middle Bronze Age	Middle Minoan Middle Cycladic Middle Helladic
1600–1100 B.C.	Late Bronze Age	Late Minoan Late Cycladic Late Helladic; also the Mycenaean Age

Minoan Civilization

The Minoan civilization grew to maturity in the Middle Bronze Age and reached its pinnacle of greatness in the following period (1600–1400 B.C.). The palace at Cnossus was particularly splendid (although another at Phaestus is impressive, too). The excavations confirm the tradition (as interpreted later, for example, by Thucydides 1.8.2) that Cnossus was the capital of a great thalassocracy (sea-power) and that Minoan power extended over the islands of the Aegean and even the mainland of Greece. The complex plan of the palace at Cnossus suggests the historical basis for the legend of the labyrinth and the slaying of the Minotaur by Theseus. Tribute was in all probability exacted from her allies or her subjects: Cnossus could have won temporary control over Athens, and the monarchy there could have been forced to pay tribute for a time; but subsequently, Athens would have won freedom from Cretan domination. The fact that Cnossus had no walls (unlike the fortress citadels of Hellas) indicates that its confident security depended on ships and the sea. The sophistication of Minoan

Snake Goddess from the Palace at Cnossos. Glazed earthenware figure (faience), ca. 1600 B.C., discovered by Sir Arthur Evans in 1903, now in the Archaeological Museum of Heraklion on Crete. It is representative of so many such figures unearthed at Minoan sites and has become iconic for much of Minoan culture. The statuette depicts a female, like those seen in Minoan frescoes, wearing an elaborate headdress and flounced skirt with open bodice and exposed breasts, holding a pair of snakes. In similar figurines, the snakes curl up the arms and around the ears of the figure. These statuettes have been used to support the still widely held theory that before the coming of the Greeks, the Minoans and early inhabitants of the Greek mainland worshiped a Great Mother Goddess. Since Linear A has yet to be deciphered, the interpretation of the meaning and function of these and other Minoan archaeological remains is elusive without any documentation. The theory that this is a representation of the Earth Mother Goddess herself (or one of her priestesses) is based on the proliferation of the figure, the presumed religious connotations of her ritual posture, her elaborate headdress, her enhanced attributes of fertility (i.e., full breasts and wide hips), and the image of the chthonic (relating to the earth) serpents. (Used with kind permission of Thomás Sakoulas and Ancient-Greece.org.)



art and architecture implies much about the civilization, but more particularly the painting and the artifacts reflect a highly developed sense of religion, for example, the importance of the bull in ritual, the dominant role of a snake goddess, and the sacred significance of the double ax (*labrys*).⁵ The word *labyrinth* may have originally meant “home of the double ax.” It seems fairly clear that the worship of a fertility mother-goddess was basic in Minoan religion.

By about 1400 B.C., Cretan power was eclipsed (archaeology reveals signs of fire and destruction), and the focus of civilization shifted to the mainland of Greece. Did the mainland Greeks overthrow Cnossos and usurp the Minoan thalassocracy, with the Athenians playing a significant role? Was an earthquake solely responsible for the eclipse of this island power? Theories abound, but there is no general agreement except insofar as scholars may be divided into two groups: those who stress the dominant influence of the Minoans on the mainland civilization and refuse to attribute the downfall of Crete to a Mycenaean invasion, as against those who argue for Mycenaean (Greek) encroachment and eventual control of the island. We incline to the latter view.

Excavations on the island of **Thera** (modern Santorini, about 70 miles northwest of Crete) have unearthed exciting new finds, among them interesting frescoes, and have indicated clear signs of destruction by earthquakes in the Minoan-Mycenaean period which may be dated ca. 1600 B.C. It had been conjectured that these same earthquakes were responsible for the disintegration of power on the island of Crete, but they now appear to have occurred earlier. At any rate, archaeologists have turned to the mythical tale about Atlantis (recorded by Plato in his *Critias* and *Timaeus*), a great island culture that vanished into the sea; conflict between Atlantis and Attica for control of the sea had broken out when earthquake and flood caused the astonishing disappearance of Atlantis. Does this Platonic legend reflect in any way the actual destruction of Thera, or of Crete itself, and the subsequent encroachment of Mycenaean power?⁶ Again no certain answer is forthcoming.

The Mycenaean Age

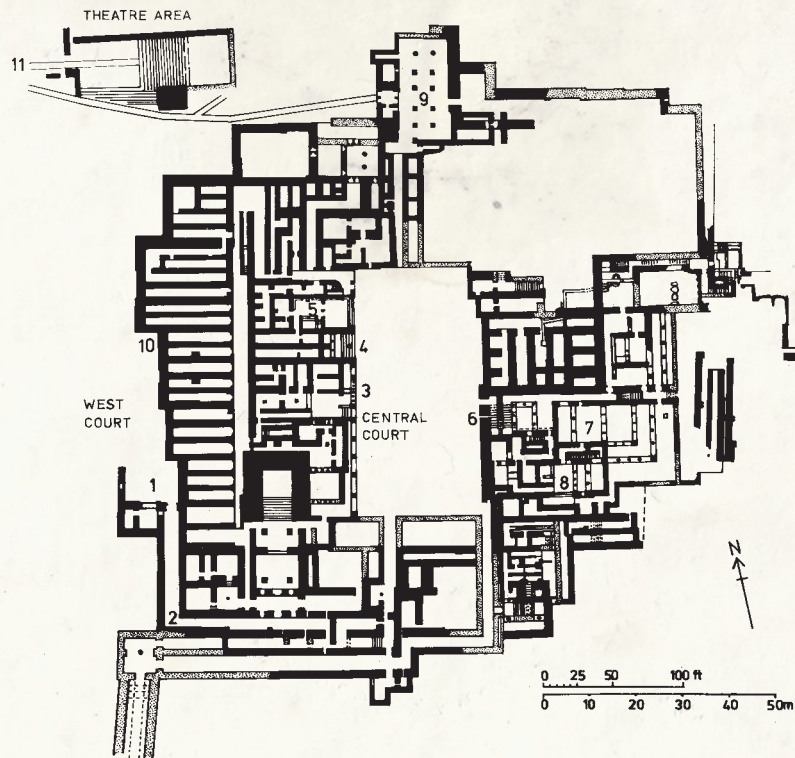
On the mainland of Greece, the Middle Bronze Age (or Middle Helladic period) was ushered in by an invasion from the north and possibly the east. These Indo-Europeans are the first Greeks (i.e., they spoke the Greek language) to enter the peninsula, and they brought with them the worship of a supreme god of the sky,

The Palace at Cnossus

In the *Odyssey*, Odysseus, disguised as a Cretan prince, dissembles about the many cities of his professed homeland, Crete, and says that "among them was Cnossus, a great city, and there Minos, friend of almighty Zeus, ruled for nine years" (*Odyssey* 19.179–180). In 1899, Sir Arthur Evans began his excavations at Cnossus and uncovered a prehistoric civilization previously known only through myth and tradition. Because of the association of the legendary King Minos with Crete (see pp. 593, 600–603), Evans called the civilization that he unearthed "Minoan." The excavations revealed the presence of a prosperous and sophisticated culture on

Diagram of Palace at Cnossus.

This plan of the palace is based on Sir Arthur Evans's original, complex reconstruction of the site. Subsequent archaeologists have argued for modifications. (GRAHAM, JAMES WALTER; *THE PALACES OF CRETE* © 1962 Princeton University Press, 1969 revised edition, 1990 renewed PUP Reprinted by permission of Princeton University Press)



The Palace at Knossos.

- | | | |
|------------------------------|---------------------------|---------------------------------|
| 1 West Porch | 5 Throne Room | 9 Pillar Hall |
| 2 Corridor of the Procession | 6 Grand Staircase | 10 Store-rooms |
| 3 Palace Shrine | 7 Hall of the Double Axes | 11 Royal Road, to Little Palace |
| 4 Stepped porch | 8 'Queen's Megaron' | |

Crete during the Bronze Age and confirmed the tradition of the dominant position of Cnossus. According to Evans, at the center of Minoan civilization was the palace, which was organized around a large, central court surrounded by storerooms, workshops, and living spaces. The palace at Cnossus was begun around 1700 B.C. and grew over the course of many years in a seemingly haphazard fashion, as space was needed. As a result, it is tempting to see in the mazelike complexity of the palace's layout and the ubiquitous bull motif a historical reality behind the legend of the Minotaur in the labyrinth and its link with Theseus.



North Entrance Passage, Cnossus. Archaeologists have found in this passage area some of the best-preserved frescoes in the debris at Cnossus. The bull's head, originally part of a more complete scene of a charging bull or a feat of "bull-grappling", is now in the Herakleion Museum. Evans believed the fresco decorated the wall behind the columns. The reconstructed fresco pictured here on site follows Evans conjecture, though doubt has been cast on the location of the original fresco.

named Zeus. Gradually, they created a civilization (usually called Mycenaean) that reached its culmination in the Late Helladic period (1600–1100 B.C.).⁷ They learned much from the Minoans; their painting, palaces, and pottery are strikingly similar, but there are some significant differences. Schliemann was the first to excavate at **Mycenae** (in 1876), the kingdom of the mythological family of Atreus, corroborating the appropriateness of the Homeric epithet, “rich in gold.” **Cyclopean** walls (so huge and monumental that they were said to be built by the giant Cyclopes of myth) typically surround the complex palace of the king and the homes of the aristocracy; the entrance to Mycenae was particularly splendid, graced as it was with a relief on which two lions or lionesses flanking a column were sculptured—presumably the relief was of political and religious significance, perhaps the emblem of the royal family. A circle of **shaft graves** within the citadel, set off in ritual splendor, has revealed a hoard of treasures—masks of beaten gold placed on the faces of the corpses, exquisite jewelry, and beautifully decorated weapons. Larger (and later) **tholos tombs** (also typical of Mycenaean civilization elsewhere and confirming a belief in the afterlife), built like huge beehives into the sides of hills below the palace complex, were dramatically and erroneously identified by Schliemann as both the treasury of Atreus and the tomb of Clytemnestra.

Schliemann’s discoveries established the certainty of a link between the traditional tales of Greek saga, especially those contained in the Homeric poems, and the actual places named in the poems, for example, Mycenae. Archaeologists have proved that these places were prosperous centers during the Mycenaean Age, and the distinction must be appreciated between the legends of heroes associated with Mycenaean palaces (Agamemnon at Mycenae, Heracles at Tiryns, Oedipus at Thebes, and Nestor at Pylos, to name four such heroes) and the actual world revealed by archaeologists. Carl Blegen’s discovery (1939, 1952–1969) of the Mycenaean palace at **Pylos** settled once and for all the controversy over its site and established the plan of the palace, with its well-preserved **megaron** (i.e., central room with an open hearth); and his conclusion that this is the palace of the family of Nestor seems inevitable. It is difficult to imagine to what families, other than those of the legends, these citadels could have belonged. Yet, of course, we must be wary of a naive belief in the details of the poetic tradition.

In religion, there were important differences between the Minoans and the Mycenaeans. The northern invaders of 2000 B.C. worshiped in particular a sky-god, Zeus, and in general their religious attitudes were not unlike those mirrored in the world of Homer’s celestial Olympians. How different from the spiritual atmosphere of the Minoans dominated by the conception of a fertility mother-goddess, with or without a male counterpart! At any rate, Greek mythology seems to accommodate and reflect the union of these two cultures, as we shall see in Chapter 3.

Linear B

Clay tablets inscribed with writing have been found on the mainland (an especially rich hoard was found at Pylos, which helped immeasurably in their decipherment). These tablets were baked hard in the conflagrations that destroyed these Mycenaean fortresses when they fell before the onslaught of the invaders.⁸ The key to deciphering the Linear B tablets was discovered in 1952 by Michael Ventris, who was killed in 1956 in an accident. His friend and collaborator, John Chadwick, has written for the layperson a fascinating account of their painstaking and exciting work on the tablets, one of the most significant scholastic and linguistic detective



Reconstruction of the Megaron at Pylos, by Piet de Jong; watercolor, originally from the Archaeological Museum in Chora, now in the Ephoreia of Olympia. Before modern color photography and computer-generated imagery became a commonplace tool for the archaeologist, Piet de Jong was one of the most prolific of archaeology illustrators, and his vision of the reconstruction of Minoan, Mycenaean, and later Greek spaces and art has influenced subsequent generations in terms of how they reimagine these lost worlds. He worked with some of the most famous names in the early days of archaeology, including Carl Blegen (see p. 44), who discovered and excavated the site of the palace of Nestor at Pylos. The megaron is a feature of Mycenaean architecture and is not to be found in Minoan palaces. The floor of the megaron with its central hearth is one of the best preserved of its type. The reconstruction here, except for the details of the floor and the hearth itself, is conjectural; the position of the throne (along the back wall) is based on archaeological evidence. The painted patterns on the hearth, such as tongues of flame, and the linear designs of various colors, set out in squares upon the floor, are still visible today. (Watercolor by Piet de Jong. Digitally edited by Craig Mauzy. Courtesy of the Department of Classics, University of Cincinnati.)



Closer Look

stories of this or any other age.⁹ It was, however, Emmett L. Bennett Jr. who was the founding father of the study of Mycenaean scripts, and his preliminary work on the Linear B tablets contributed greatly to their final decipherment by Ventris. While working on his PhD (completed in 1947) at the University of Cincinnati with Carl Blegen, who had unearthed hundreds of Linear B tablets in his excavation of Pylos, Bennett was given the golden opportunity to undertake his invaluable, pioneering work. Important for our study is the finding of the names of familiar deities of classical Greece: Zeus and Hera (listed as a pair), Poseidon, Hermes, Athena, Artemis, Eileithyia (Eleuthia in the tablets), and the name of the god Dionysus (a truly startling discovery, since it had usually been assumed that the worship of Dionysus did not come to Greece until after the Mycenaean age); also identified is an early form of the word *paean*, which was later applied as a title or epithet for Apollo. Similarly, Enualios appears, a name identified in classical times with Ares. The word *potnia* (mistress or lady) is frequent, and thus support is added to the theory that the Mycenaeans as well as the Minoans worshiped a goddess of the mother-fertility type and that the concept of chthonian (i.e., of the earth) deities

that this implies was merged with that of the Olympians. The gods are listed in the tablets as the recipients of offerings (i.e., of animals, olive oil, wheat, wine, and honey), which suggests ritual sacrifice and ceremonial banquets.

Linear B tablets have been found in some ten excavations in Mycenaean Greece and Crete. In 1993–1995, a large archive of tablets (over 259) was unearthed in Thebes. Those translated thus far confirm that in the thirteenth century B.C. Thebes controlled a powerful and rich kingdom with an impressive network of relationships. Such was the importance of the place founded by Cadmus and where Dionysus was born, with its many legends including those about the family of Oedipus. Cadmus is actually named by a Mycenaean king as one of that monarch's predecessors (probably in the fifteenth century) in a letter written in Hittite to the Great King of the Hittites. The catalogue of the ships in Book 2 of Homer's *Iliad* is historical in the prominent place given to Boeotia, from whose harbor at Aulis the Mycenaean expedition set sail against Troy.

Troy and the Trojan War

Frank Calvert, an amateur archaeologist who had lived for some time in the area of the Dardanelles, was convinced that Hisarlik was the site of Troy. He undertook a preliminary investigation (1863–1868) but did not have the finances to continue. The wealthy Heinrich Schliemann, convinced by Calvert's work and inspired by Homer's *Iliad*, proceeded with a more thorough excavation (1870–1873 and 1879–1890), accompanied by the architect Wilhelm Dörpfeld, who, after Schliemann's death, continued his mission (1882–1890). Carl Blegen was the next archaeologist to provide a significant reexamination of the site, from 1932 to 1938; after Blegen's, excavations have been renewed since 1988 by a team of archaeologists led by Manfred Korfmann from the University of Tübingen (Germany) and C. Brian Rose, who like Blegen before him is from the University of Cincinnati.¹⁰

Troy I–VI

There were nine settlements on the site of Troy, situated at the hill of Hisarlik. **Troy I** was settled in the Early Bronze Age (ca. 2920–2450 B.C.), and there continued to be successive settlements on the site for a long period of history. It was an important city in the historical Greek period (Troy VIII, Ilion, ca. 700–85 B.C.). The Romans restored the city on a large scale in the first century A.D. (Troy IX, Ilium, 85 B.C.–ca. A.D. 500); the imperial family of Augustus Caesar honored the city as the home of their ancestor Aeneas. It existed in the time of Constantine the Great (in the fourth century) but fell into disuse in the sixth century. Because of Homer and the renowned legend of the Trojan War, which the ancients accepted as historical fact, Troy became a revered site of Greek honor and glory.

Of the seven major settlements in the Minoan-Mycenaean period (Troy I–VII), **Troy II** (ca. 2600–2450 B.C., the citadel contemporary with the Late Troy I settlement) is particularly interesting because of treasure Schliemann claimed to have found at that level and his inaccurate assumption that he had found the city of Priam and the Trojan War. A picture that has become famous shows Schliemann's wife Sophia decked out in some of the jewelry from this treasure (called "The Gold of Troy" or "Priam's Treasure"), which Schliemann gave to the Berlin Museum. It disappeared during World War II, and not until the 1990s did the world learn that it resided in the Pushkin Museum in Moscow. When the Red Army overran Berlin at the end of

World War II, it shipped the valuable treasure off to Russia.¹¹ **Troy III–V** belong to the Early and Middle Bronze Ages (the period ca. 2450–1700 B.C.). **Troy VI** (Troia or Ilios, ca. 1700–1250 B.C., Middle-Late Bronze Age) was identified by Dörpfeld as the city of the Trojan War. The collapse of Troy VI is dated around 1250 B.C. by the new excavators, who believe that the final building phase was ended by a severe earthquake. The fortification walls of Troy VI are particularly impressive, and Dörpfeld identified this settlement as the great city of King Priam, besieged and taken by the Greeks. According to Blegen, however, Troy VI was devastated by an earthquake, but it was the next city, **Troy VII (Troy VIIa to be exact)**, that was the scene of the Trojan War, since for Blegen the evidence seems to provide signs of a siege and fire, indicative of the Trojan War: burnt debris and human skeletal remains, amid signs of devastation, wrought by invaders. For him the fall of Troy VIIa (not Troy VI) occurred around 1250. The new excavators date Troy VII at about 1250–1040 B.C., Late Bronze Age–Early Iron Age, its first phase VIIa ending around 1150 B.C. There is a continuity of culture between Troy VI and Troy VIIa; the ruins of houses and citadel walls were reused for repairs; buildings are much smaller, more cramped, and clearly arranged; the style of pottery remains Mycenaean; and the population and number of storage vessels are increased. All signs of a city under siege? After all, both Troy VI and Troy VIIa could be the city of Priam in two different phases. Blegen may, after all, be right, but of course much is in great dispute. Thus far, at any rate, Korfmann's conclusions seem to support Blegen's thesis.

Troy VI–VIIa: The City of Priam

The conclusion seems inevitable that the excavated Troy (whether Troy VI or Troy VIIa, or both) must be the city of Priam that fell to the Greeks; as for chronology, the approximate date of the conflict was 1250–1150 B.C., not too far from the traditionally accepted date of ca. 1184 B.C. for the fall of Troy.¹²

The citadel for Troy VI was newly constructed in eight successive stages, its size greater than any so far found in western Asia Minor, indicating its prestige and power. The fortifications consist of gently sloping walls of ashlar masonry, 4 to 5 meters thick and over 6 meters high, topped by a superstructure of mud-brick, with the inclusion of massive towers. The principal palaces on the summit no longer survive, but remains of large, impressive buildings have been found along the edge of the acropolis within the fortifications. There were several gates leading into the citadel, the principal one to the south, flanked by a tower.

The excavations that are in progress reveal that in Troy VI/VIIa the fortified upper citadel of the king was linked to a lower town by a defensive wall that surrounded it, making the size of the whole settlement approximately 200,000 square meters with a population of roughly 5,000–10,000 inhabitants. A ditch cut in the bedrock defined the outer limit of the inhabited city. This ditch was part of the defensive system, intended as an obstacle to delay attackers before they reached a wall, just north of it, “an arrow's throw” (according to Korfmann), about 90–120 meters from the ditch, on the side of the town.¹³ The fortification wall beyond the ditch was of stone, its upper section of mud-brick, enhanced by a wooden palisade with a sentry walk. (Where this wall of the lower town joined up to the northeast bastion of the citadel can be identified.) There are also clear indications of a causeway running through the palisade, in which a double wooden entrance gate was constructed, with a south gate offering controlled access to a major street through the lower town.

Astronomical Evidence in Homer for the Chronology of the Trojan War?

In Book 20 of the *Odyssey*, during a banquet of the suitors (at which Odysseus, disguised as a beggar, is present), the suitor Ageläus claims that Odysseus will never return and urges Telemachus to tell Penelope that she must marry one of them. Telemachus replies that he has told his mother to marry whomever she wishes. Homer describes the scene that follows and foreshadows the death of the suitors (345–358):

Thus spoke Telemachus. Then Pallas Athena instilled an unquenchable laughter in the suitors and befuddled their minds and they laughed with lips that seemed not their own. The meat that they were eating became sprinkled with blood, their eyes filled with tears and they thought that they were groaning laments. Among them, the seer Theoclymenus spoke: "Poor wretches, what is this evil you are suffering? Your heads, your faces, your knees, you are completely shrouded in night. Cries of wailing have been aroused. Spattered with blood are the walls and beautiful panels. The entrance and also the courtyard are full of ghosts going below in the dark to the gloom of the Underworld. The sun has been obliterated from the sky and an ill-omened darkness has fallen." These were his words but they all laughed at him happily.

The allegorist Heraclitus in the first century A.D. and Plutarch both interpreted the last sentence of Theoclymenus' prophecy ("The sun has been obliterated from the sky and an ill-omened darkness has fallen") as a poetic description of a total solar eclipse (when the moon blocks the sun briefly but completely). In 1926, C. Schoch (followed by P. V. Neugebauer) argued that Homer could be referring to a real and specific solar eclipse and identified it as the one that occurred on April 16, 1178 B.C., which would have been visible over the Ionian Islands. If this conclusion is correct, the fall of Troy would then have to be dated ca. 1188, since Odysseus traveled for ten years afterward, before he arrived home in Ithaca. Therefore, this astronomical evidence would provide yet another confirmation of the traditional and archaeological dates for Troy's fall in the period 1250–1150.

In subsequent years, the work of Schoch was evidently too hastily dismissed, and only recently has it found serious support as a result of the research of Marcelo O. Magnasco, head of the Laboratory of Mathematical Physics of the Rockefeller University in New York, and Constantino Baikouzis of the Observatorio Astronómico in La Plata, Argentina. They have scrupulously identified other astronomical indications in the *Odyssey* that may be linked to their argument, among them the presence of a new moon, a prerequisite for a total eclipse. They also readily admit the number of limitations and controversial issues inherent in their analysis, but they hope that other scholars may be inspired to pursue further research. The ingenuity and honesty of this painstaking astronomical scrutiny of Homer's text by two biophysicists of repute make their conclusions provocative.¹⁴

The main entrance to the upper citadel of Troy VI/VIIa was from the west, on the seaward side. A broad paved road, affording easy and dangerous access, led gently uphill to the fortress wall and ended at the largest gate in the fortress wall. (There was also a city gate here on the west side, very close, only about 80 meters, to the fortress gate.) Korfmann rightfully sees this topography reflected in the *Iliad*. This most vulnerable section of the fortress wall not only offered a clear view as far as Tenedos over the plain, which the attackers must have crossed,



Model of Troy VI, from Joachim Latacz, *Troy and Homer (Troia und Homer)*, translated by K. Windle and R. Ireland (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2004), p. 33, fig. 8. The model illustrates the results of the work of Manfred Korfmann (1952–2005) at Troy between 1988 and 2003. It shows the city that was possibly the immediate predecessor of Priam's Troy (Troy VII), destroyed by an earthquake in about 1250 B.C. and soon rebuilt. The citadel, with the royal palace and the houses of the elite Trojans, is at the top center, and below it is the lower town, inhabited by the ordinary citizens. The whole, with an extent of 200,000 square meters, was surrounded by a wall and a ditch. In the distance, about 8 kilometers away, lies the sea. (Christoph Haussner, Munich)

but also it was the only place where these Mycenaean warriors would have come close enough to be identified.

The recent excavations provide greater proof than ever that Troy VI/VIIa was a significant, palatial center, with its fortress citadel and inhabited lower town protected by a ditch and a wall—certainly compatible with the wealth and power of King Priam, celebrated in the heroic tradition.

The excavators have also found, just as Blegen did, indications within the lower town of a violent destruction for the end of Troy VIIa, for example, a hastily buried fifteen-year-old female and “a number of long-range weapons, such as arrowheads and spearheads, and over one hundred stone pellets, probably used for slings, which were piled in heaps. This may indicate defeat in battle because successful defenders usually clean up such piles, whereas victorious aggressors tend not to care about them.”

The Luwian Seal from Troy

Perhaps the most exciting find of all is a small round bronze seal (biconvex, i.e., convex on both sides) found in a one-room house. This first prehistoric inscription from Troy is to be dated in the second half of the twelfth century. Such seals

(which come in various types) are common and abundant because of the need to mark and identify one's own property with a stamp. Biconvex seals are a special type, usually with one side bearing the name of an official and the other the name of his wife. The language of the seal is Luwian, an Indo-European language like Hittite, of which it is a dialect. Traditional cuneiform Hittite (the official language of diplomacy) can be read today, but hieroglyphic Hittite, a complex pictographic script used for Luwian, has only recently been deciphered after prolonged research; complete decipherment has yet to be achieved. The Luwian language became a kind of demotic to high Hittite and was used widely among a multilingual population because it was more easily comprehensible. The text of the Luwian seal from Troy is poorly preserved. The personal names are illegible, but the title of the man is translated as *scribe* or *master-scribe*, and on the other side the word *wife*. Much (indeed, far too much) has been inferred from this one and only seal. That Luwian was a language used in Troy is credible, but there must have been many more languages in this international hub. That it was the major language of the Trojans is a much less likely conjecture. They may have spoken Greek. Perhaps in this case, too, Homer is right. Hector and Achilles could communicate with one another, and so could Paris with Helen. After all, the Trojans were descended from the same Indo-Europeans (identified as ancestors of the Mycenaean Greeks) who around 2000 B.C. came down into Greece from the north and also across the Dardenelles into Asia Minor. There is now real hope that more examples of writing may be found, perhaps in other houses in Troy VI/VIIa or in the tons of rubble that remain from Schliemann's excavations.

Hittite documents have emerged to offer vital new insights into the history of the Bronze Age. These texts "indicate strong connections between the Hittite kingdom and 'Wilusa,' which should probably be identified with Troy." Also, one of the texts (called the Alaksandu treaty) identifies among the deities of Wilusa a deity named Appaliunas, almost certainly the name for Apollo, the great god who took the side of the Trojans in the *Iliad*. The cult of Apollo is believed to be Anatolian or Cypriot in origin; after all, Homer does call him "Lycian-born." There are thousands of other such Hittite texts, which should be so enlightening, but sad to say they remain unread, waiting, waiting for willing scholars trained in the decipherment of cuneiform.

The Greek Armada Lands at Besika Bay

Other excavations under Korfmann's direction in the area of the Troad have unearthed further confirmation for the authenticity of Homeric geography and legend. Five miles southwest of Troy lies Besika Bay, where the original seashore at the time of the Trojan War has been identified; nearby, a cemetery containing about 200 graves surrounded by a single wall has been unearthed; the cremations and burials were accompanied by pottery and funeral offerings that are unmistakably Mycenaean and of the thirteenth century (the period of late Troy VI or Troy VIIa). It is difficult to resist the identification of this cemetery as that of the camp of the invading Greeks and Besika Bay, from which the island of Tenedos can be seen about 6 miles away, as the harbor where the Greeks anchored and encamped.

The Tomb of Achilles

Nearby is the headland of Yassi Tepe (formerly named Cape Troy) where there rises a great cone-shaped tumulus, Besik Tepe (now called Sivri Tepe), which most

certainly goes back to the Bronze Age and very probably is the great tumulus mentioned by Homer. It must also be the mound, believed in classical times to be the tomb of Achilles and visited by Xerxes and Alexander the Great. Alexander inspired by his love of the *Iliad*, saw himself and his comrade Hephaestion as a second Achilles and Patroclus. Another famous visitor to Troy was Xerxes, king of the Persians. On his march against Greece in 480 B.C., he was anxious to see the ancient and celebrated city of great King Priam. After he made a tour of the citadel and asked about the stirring legends of the Trojan War, he sacrificed oxen to Trojan Athena, and priests poured libations of wine to the heroes of old who had died there.

The Reality of the Trojan War

A detailed examination of abundant evidence confirms that Troy was a major center of commerce and trade in the second millennium. The city held the Hittite Empire at bay and remained relatively independent, eventually becoming a major contender in maritime traffic, with a stronghold on the vital area of the Black Sea, possibly even charging tolls for ships traveling through the Dardanelles. Serious economic reasons can easily be conjured up as legitimate causes for the Trojan War. After the Mycenaeans had conquered Cnossus, they aggressively assumed control of the Aegean and during the thirteenth century particularly, interfered frequently and significantly in the military and monetary affairs of western Asia Minor, even gaining for a time a foothold in Miletus. It was inevitable that they would finally move against Troy, a most pernicious rival.

In the epic cycle of saga, the great leaders of the Mycenaean kingdoms banded together to sail against Troy, and, even though the historical facts may be a matter of conjecture, the romance of this poetic legend has a reality too. Until it is disproven, we have every right to believe that there once were an Agamemnon and a Clytemnestra, a Hector and an Andromache and an Achilles, who lived and died, no matter how fictitious the details of the story that they inspired; and handsome Paris and beautiful Helen ran away together in the grip of Aphrodite, providing the inciting cause for a great war that has become immortal. The rigorously scientific, contemporary archaeologist and historian will settle for nothing less than written proof for the authenticity of the war and reality of its leaders. Perhaps the time is now here at last for the realization that all sorts of cumulative evidence (not only written records) from recent investigations in support of belief has become overwhelming.¹⁵

Carl Blegen, on the basis of much good evidence already acquired, wrote in 1963: "It can no longer be doubted, when one surveys the state of our knowledge today, that there really was an actual historical Trojan War in which a coalition of Achaeans, or Mycenaeans, under a king whose overlordship was recognized, fought against the people of Troy and their allies." His conviction gains further substantial support daily, and he would be gratified by the knowledge that Korfmann and many others today confidently use Homer as a secondary source of consequence, with intelligent caution of course, just the way he did.¹⁶

End of the Mycenaean Age

The destruction of the later phases of Troy VII (VIIb, to the beginning of the tenth century B.C.) marked the troublesome period of transition from the Late Bronze Age to the Age of Iron. The Greeks, we are to assume, returned from Troy

Timeline of Historical Events and Authors

7000–3000 B.C.	Neolithic Age	
3000–2000 B.C. 2000 B.C.	Early Greek Bronze age Greek-speaking peoples enter Greece	Oral Transmission of Myth and Legend
2000–1600 B.C.	Middle Bronze Age The flowering of Minoan civilization and the dominance of Cnossus	
1600–1100 B.C.	Late Bronze Age: The Mycenaean Age Mycenaean dominance over the Minoans	
1250–1150 B.C. 1184 B.C.	Period of the collapse of Troy VI and VII A traditional date for the fall of Troy	
1100–800 B.C.	Dark Age The Dorian invasion and the beginning of the Iron Age	
800–480 B.C. 546 B.C.	Archaic Period Cyrus the Great extends the Persian empire with the sack of Sardis and the defeat of Croesus, King of Lydia	Invention of the Greek Alphabet Homer (Iliad and Odyssey) Epic Cycle Hesiod (Theogony and Works and Days) Homeric Hymns Lyric Poets
753–509 B.C.	The founding of Rome by Romulus and the monarchy to the establishment of the Republic	
480–323 B.C. 480 B.C.	Classical Period The Persians sack Athens and destroy the temples on the Acropolis	Pindar (Victory Odes) Aeschylus, Sophocles, Euripides (Tragedy)
447–438 B.C.	Construction of the Parthenon as part of Pericles' building program	Herodotus (History) Thucydides (History) Aristophanes (Comedy) Plato (Philosophy) Aristotle (Philosophy)

323–31 B.C.	Hellenistic period	
323 B.C.	Death of Alexander the Great	<i>Callimachus (Hymns)</i> <i>Apollonius of Rhodes (Argonautica)</i>
1st Century B.C.	Late Roman Republic	<i>Lucretius (Epic)</i> <i>Catullus (Lyric)</i>
27 B.C.–A.D. 284	Early Roman Empire	<i>Vergil (Eclogues, Georgics, and Aeneid)</i>
27 B.C.–A.D. 14	Rule of Augustus, first Emperor of Rome	<i>Ovid (Metamorphoses, Fasti, etc.)</i> <i>Livy (Ab urbe condita)</i> <i>Seneca (Tragedy)</i> <i>Valerius Flaccus (Argonautica)</i> <i>Statius (Thebaid)</i> <i>Apollodorus (Library of Greek Mythology)</i> <i>Lucian (Mythological Satire)</i> <i>Apuleius (Metamorphoses or The Golden Ass)</i> <i>Pausanias (Description of Greece)</i> <i>Hyginus (Genealogies)</i>
A.D. 284–476	Later Empire to the Fall of Rome	
A.D. 313	Edict of Milan under Constantine establishes religious tolerance for Christianity	
A.D. 361–363	Julian the Apostate, the last non-Christian emperor, attempts to revive pagan worship	
A.D. 380	Theodosius establishes Christianity as the only legitimate religion and closes pagan sanctuaries	
A.D. 476	The fall of Rome	<i>Fulgentius (Mythologies)</i>

Homer

A cogent interpretation of the evidence offers answers to some of the many Homeric questions, amidst all the controversy. In the *Odyssey* (1. 350–351), when the bard Phemius sings of the disasters that the Achaeans suffered upon their return from Troy (so painful for Penelope to hear), Telemachus observes that the audience applauds most for the most recent tales. In a later book (8. 487–534), Demodocus at the request of Odysseus (whose identity is not known) sings readily about the wooden horse and the fall of Troy with such art that Odysseus is brought to tears. The recitation of oral poetry to the accompaniment of the lyre (phorminx) was part of the fabric of Mycenaean civilization. (A splendid fresco of a lyre player was found at Pylos.) The story of the Trojan War in all likelihood was first told simultaneously with the event or soon afterward, to be transmitted in a continuous tradition by generations of subsequent poets, with modifications, elaborations, and infinite creative variations. The Dorian invasion bringing an end to Mycenaean civilization (ca. 1100 B.C.) is now believed to have been less disruptive than previously thought. The poetic transmission, however, was in rigidly structured lines (the meter being dactylic hexameter), which was conducive to the retention of historical fact. A large body of repetitive formulaic material of varying types and lengths was crystallized (e.g., “swift-footed Achilles,” “rosy-fingered dawn,” or the set pattern of sacrificial ritual), to be drawn upon readily and to facilitate impromptu oral recitation before an audience. A highly skilled guild of professional rhapsodists (called Homeridae or Homerids) developed, and by the time of Homer oral epic had reached a pinnacle of artistic perfection. It was Homer who composed the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey* orally and was possibly the one who had the poems set down in writing in the eighth century B.C. Despite the centuries between the time of Homer and the Trojan War, the poet transmits much accurate historical detail that can come only from the period of the Trojan War. The most compelling example (among many others) is the catalogue of the ships (2. 494–759), which does not fit comfortably in its later context in the *Iliad* and describes an earlier political and geographical world that can only be Mycenaean. Credible is the tradition that a standard text of both poems was established in Athens at the time of the Pisistratid tyranny in the second half of the sixth century B.C.

in triumph. Yet not long after their return, the Mycenaean Age in Greece was brought to a violent end, perhaps precipitated by internal dissension. The widely held theory that the destruction was entirely the work of **Dorians** invading from the north and east has been questioned. Some historians not very convincingly associate the destruction of the Mycenaean kingdoms with the “sea peoples” mentioned in an Egyptian inscription put up by the pharaoh Rameses III in the twelfth century B.C., but there is still no certainty about the details of the end of the Bronze Age in Greece.

Darkness descends on the history of Greece, a darkness that is only gradually dispelled with the emergence of the two great Homeric epics, the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey*, in the eighth century B.C. The stories of the earlier period were kept alive by oral recitation, transmitted by bards like those described in the epics themselves. “Homer” almost certainly belongs to Asia Minor or one of the islands (e.g., Chios) off the coast. In the cities of this area in this period, we find that monarchy is the prevailing institution; significantly enough, the social and political